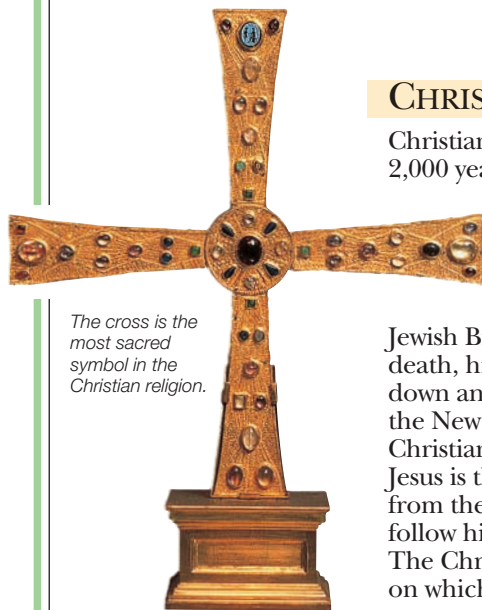


WORLD RELIGIONS

THROUGHOUT HISTORY, people have asked about the meaning of life and death and have sought answers through religion. There are many faiths throughout the world, each with its own practice and belief. Some religions, such as Christianity, have spread over the world; others, such as traditional African beliefs, have stayed in one place. The world's major faiths roughly divide into two groups – the Western tradition and the Eastern tradition. The Western tradition originated in the Near and Middle East and includes Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. The Eastern tradition began in India and includes Hinduism and Buddhism.



The cross is the most sacred symbol in the Christian religion.

CHRISTIANITY

Christianity was founded around 2,000 years ago by Jesus Christ, who was born in the town of Bethlehem, in present-day Israel. Jesus was born into the Jewish faith, but interpreted the Jewish Bible in a new way. After his death, his teachings were written down and collected together in the New Testament of the Bible. Christians believe in one God, that Jesus is the Son of God, that he rose from the dead, and that those who follow him will have eternal life. The Christian symbol is the cross on which Jesus was killed.

DIVISIONS OF CHRISTIANITY

More than half of all Christians are Roman Catholics, who follow the leadership of the Pope in Rome. There are large numbers of Catholics in southern Europe, Central and South America, and Philippines. One-quarter of Christians are Protestants, who split from the Catholic Church 500 years ago, and belong to a number of self-governing churches. The main areas of Protestantism are in northern Europe and North America. About one in 10 Christians belong to one of the Eastern Orthodox Churches of Eastern Europe and Russia; each national church has its own Patriarch, or leader.

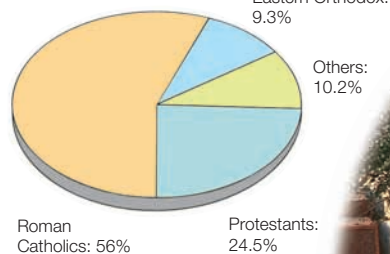


The Torah is a Jewish sacred scroll and is made up of the first five books of the Old Testament.

JUDAISM

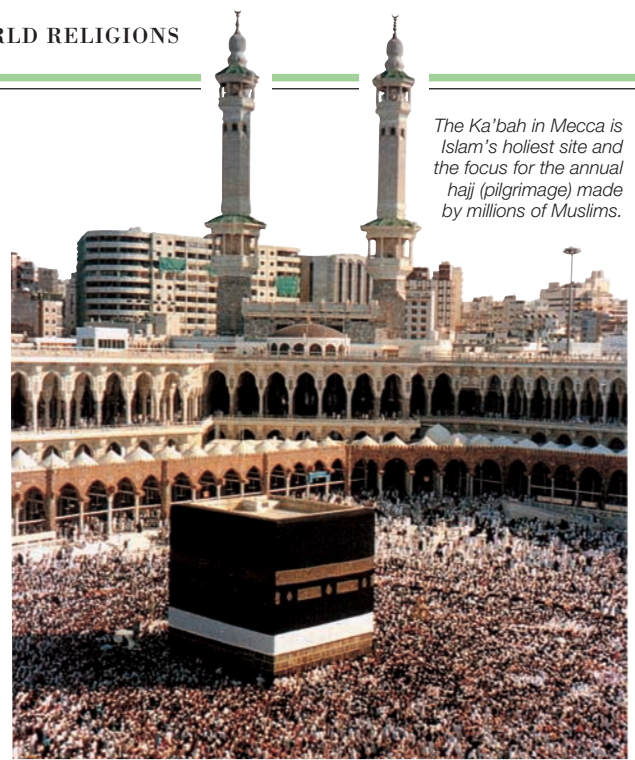
Judaism, the religion of the Jews, began in about 2000 BC when the ancient Hebrew people settled in what is now mainly Israel. Judaism is the parent of the other two major monotheist (one-god) religions, Christianity and Islam. There is no single founder, but Abraham was the first leader. The scripture is the Jewish Bible, of which the Torah (the first five books) is the most important part. After persecution in Europe, the Jewish people established a homeland in Israel in 1948, although Jews are found in most countries of the world. The Jewish symbol is the six-pointed Star of David.

Types of Christians

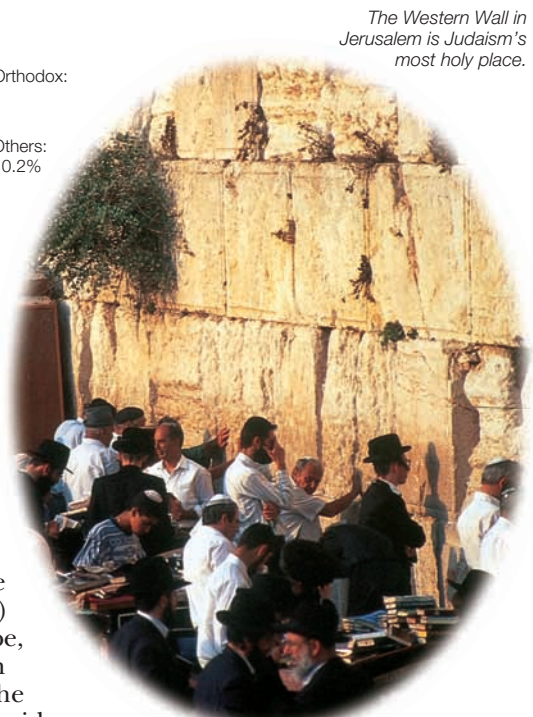


ISLAM

Muslims follow the Islamic faith, based on a belief in one God, Allah. Islam shares the same roots as Judaism and Christianity, all three recognizing certain prophets, such as Abraham. Followers believe the last and greatest of the Islamic prophets was Mohammad, who was born in Mecca, Saudi Arabia, in 570. The words revealed to Mohammad by Allah were later written down in the Koran. After Mohammad's death, Islam split into two branches: the traditional Sunnis, who follow Mohammad's original successors (the Caliphs), and the radical Shi'ites, who followed Mohammad's cousin and son-in-law, Ali. Shi'ites are the majority in Iran and Iraq, Sunnis the majority elsewhere.



The Ka'bah in Mecca is Islam's holiest site and the focus for the annual hajj (pilgrimage) made by millions of Muslims.



The Western Wall in Jerusalem is Judaism's most holy place.